VUGA NDAKUMVA INITIATIVE

GBV EDUCATIONAL LIBRARY / CHAPTER 08

Economic Violence and Financial Control

Understanding coercion through money, work, resources, property, and financial access - and how to support survivors safely.

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Includes: 18 learning sections, 5 case studies, 5 activities, 10 assessment questions, glossary, Rwanda support information, and references.

Prepared for educational and professional review. Not an individualized safety plan or legal advice.

How to use this chapter

This chapter is designed for readers, educators, community facilitators, and GBV awareness programs. Readers may skip activities or pause at any time. Do not ask people to disclose personal experiences during group learning.

> Safety first: Avoid instructions that could increase danger, such as changing a monitored PIN, confronting an abusive person, or secretly moving funds without individualized safety advice.

Learning objectives

- Define economic abuse and distinguish it from ordinary financial disagreements.
- Recognize economic control, exploitation, employment sabotage, forced debt, and restrictions on essential needs.
- Understand why economic dependence may limit choices without blaming survivors.
- Identify safer, survivor-led support and appropriate referrals in Rwanda.
- Apply the concepts to fictional examples and check understanding.

1. Understanding economic violence

Economic violence or economic abuse occurs when a person uses money, employment, property, debt, education, benefits, or access to resources to control, exploit, or harm another person. Financial abuse is often used for direct control of income, accounts, assets, and spending; economic abuse is wider and can also undermine a person's ability to obtain or keep resources. It can occur in intimate relationships, families, care arrangements, and other settings. [1, 2]

The central concern is not whether partners share an account or earn different amounts. It is whether someone uses threats, deception, intimidation, coercion, or unequal power to deny another person genuine choice and access to necessary resources. A single incident can be serious, while some abuse develops as a repeated pattern.

Key principle: Having less income, depending on family members, or choosing to share finances

does not itself mean abuse. Control, coercion, exploitation, and the person's freedom to make decisions are critical to understanding the situation.

2. Why economic abuse matters

Economic abuse can make it harder to afford food, medication, transport, safe housing, school fees, or communication. It can undermine financial independence, interrupt education or employment, create debt, and make asking for help or leaving an abusive situation more difficult. These barriers can continue after a relationship ends. [2, 3]

Economic abuse may occur together with emotional, physical, sexual, or technology-facilitated abuse.

The presence of economic abuse does not establish that all other types are present, but it should prompt careful attention to the person's safety and choices.

3. Forms of economic violence

3.1 Restricting access to money and essentials

A controlling person may keep all income, refuse access to funds for necessary food or treatment, require receipts for every small purchase as a form of surveillance, confiscate earnings, or deny money for transport to seek help. Restrictions can become especially harmful when a person has children, a disability, or health-related needs.

3.2 Economic exploitation and property abuse

This can include taking savings, livestock, land-related proceeds, inventory, or personal possessions without agreement; using another person's bank or mobile-money account without permission; pressuring someone to transfer property; or diverting income from a jointly run business. The exact legal classification depends on the circumstances and applicable Rwandan law.

3.3 Employment and education sabotage

An abusive person may forbid employment or schooling, repeatedly interrupt work, damage tools,

interfere with a job interview, refuse reasonable childcare arrangements as a tactic of control, or harass

someone at their workplace until they lose opportunities. Sabotage can make long-term independence

harder.

3.4 Forced debts, loans, and financial documents

Someone may be pressured to borrow money, become a guarantor, hand over a PIN, sign a contract

they do not understand, or accept liability for another person's purchases. A debt may become a

mechanism of control when consent is obtained through threats or deception. A person should be able

to seek an independent explanation before making a financial commitment.

3.5 Control through technology

Digital economic abuse may involve monitoring mobile-money messages, demanding wallet or banking

PINs, accessing online accounts, requiring location-sharing to authorize purchases, or using shared

devices to track transactions. Changing access on a monitored device can sometimes alert an abusive

person, so digital safety should be considered before acting.

3.6 Withholding support and exploiting caregiving

A family member or caregiver might control an older person's funds, disability-related resources,

pension, or essential belongings. Economic abuse can affect people of any gender and age. Child

safeguarding and other legal duties may apply when a child or dependent person is involved.

4. Financial partnership versus financial control

Healthy collaboration: Partners may voluntarily choose a shared budget, discuss priorities, give one

person responsibility for paying bills, or agree to save for a business. Each person can ask questions,

understand important decisions, raise concerns without fear, and seek access to necessities.

Concerning control: One partner threatens punishment for asking about finances, takes earnings

without permission, insists on secrecy, prevents work, or uses access to basic necessities to force

compliance. What matters is the power dynamic and freedom to disagree, not simply the household

accounting arrangement. [1, 3]

5. Warning signs and patterns

- You are frightened to ask for transport, food, medical care, or access to your own earnings.
- Someone repeatedly takes your wages or mobile-money transfers, or forces you to reveal PINs.
- Work, training, education, or business activities are blocked through threats or harassment.
- You are pressured to sign loans, sell property, or transfer assets without an informed choice.
- A person closely monitors transactions as part of a wider pattern of intimidation.
- Money or support is withheld to punish you for seeing friends, seeking care, or refusing demands.

These signs invite careful reflection rather than automatic diagnosis of a relationship. A single checklist

cannot determine a person's risk. A trained GBV professional can help explore what is happening in

context.

6. Causes, power dynamics, and misconceptions

Economic abuse is linked to unequal power, controlling attitudes, gender norms, and opportunities for

exploitation. Poverty or unemployment may increase practical vulnerability, but they do not excuse

abuse. A person who experiences financial dependence is not responsible for another person's

controlling behavior. [4]

Myth: Only wealthy people can experience financial abuse. Fact: Control can involve any amount of

money or resources.

Myth: If one partner earns the money, they are entitled to control all decisions. Fact: Income differences

do not justify coercion or denial of dignity.

Myth: Economic abuse ends once people separate. Fact: Property disputes, debt, employment

disruption, and digital access may continue to affect survivors.

7. Effects on wellbeing and opportunities

Possible effects include chronic stress, fear, loss of confidence, sleep problems, limited mobility,

disrupted healthcare, interrupted schooling, job loss, food insecurity, housing instability, and difficulty

rebuilding savings. The effects vary between individuals, and some people maintain important sources

of strength and support despite abuse. [2, 3, 4]

Children may be affected when economic coercion reduces access to basic needs or creates unsafe

family conditions. Responding appropriately can require coordinated attention to social support, healthcare, education, and legal safeguards.

8. Survivor-centred first response

A supportive person should listen without judgment, acknowledge what has been shared, ask about immediate needs without demanding details, and offer choices rather than directives. Do not tell the person to confront an abuser, leave immediately, take money, expose records publicly, or disclose passwords. Such actions can increase danger in some situations.

Ask whether the conversation, device, and location are safe. Explain privacy and mandatory-reporting limits accurately. If specialized services are available, offer to help the person contact them in a way they choose. WHO's survivor-centred care principles prioritize listening, inquiry about needs, validation, safety, and support. [4, 5]

9. Financial safety: choice-based considerations

Financial safety planning should be individualized with a qualified GBV professional where possible. A person may consider the safety of identity documents, account access, emergency transportation, essential medication, business documents, and trusted contacts. The safest choices depend on monitoring, threats, dependents, and available resources. [3]

- Before using online banking or mobile money, consider whether a device, SIM card, account, or notification history is being monitored.
- Seek independent information about contracts, loans, property rights, or debts; do not sign under pressure.
- If keeping copies of documents would create danger, ask a support worker about safer alternatives.
- Discuss potential consequences before changing PINs, accounts, or communications when another person may react violently.
- You do not have to report, separate, or disclose every detail to receive respectful information and support, although some services have reporting obligations.

Immediate safety: If someone is in immediate danger, seek urgent help from an appropriate local

emergency or protection service. This chapter cannot assess an individual's risk or replace

specialist safety planning.

10. Rwanda-relevant fictional scenarios

Case A - Mobile-money control in a household

A woman who sells produce at a market receives payments through mobile money. Her spouse

demands her PIN and takes the full balance after each market day. When she asks to keep transport

and healthcare money, he threatens to stop her business.

Learning point: Taking earnings through threats and preventing access to essential funds may be

economic abuse. A supporter should ask about safety and options, not instruct her to change her PIN on

a monitored phone.

Case B - Employment interference in Kigali

An employee is repeatedly called and threatened by a partner during working hours. The partner

appears at her workplace, accuses her of wrongdoing, and says she must resign.

Learning point: Interfering with work to increase dependence is employment sabotage. Any workplace

response should consider privacy, consent, and the employee's safety.

Case C - Pressured loan in a small business

A family member pressures a young adult to sign a loan as guarantor for a business, refusing to let

them read the terms and threatening exclusion from the household if they refuse.

Learning point: Financial coercion can occur outside intimate relationships. Informed decisions require

time, accurate information, and freedom from threats.

Case D - Control of household assets in a rural district

A partner sells jointly raised livestock without discussion and refuses to share any proceeds. When

questioned, the partner uses threats and says the other person has no right to know about household

property.

Learning point: Property-related coercion may raise safety and legal issues. The actual rights over an

asset require assessment under relevant law, not assumptions from this example.

Case E - Student and education restriction

A university student is told by a financially supporting partner that tuition will be withheld unless the

student ends friendships and abandons a training opportunity.

Learning point: Using financial support as leverage to restrict autonomy may indicate coercive control.

Support should preserve the student's choice and connect them to appropriate education or social

resources.

11. Five guided learning activities

Activity 1 - Recognize the behavior

Read Case A. Identify the conduct that involves controlling funds, the potential effect on independent

decision-making, and one safe question a supporter could ask. Suggested response: Threats and taking

earnings are concerning; a safe question could be, "Is it safe for us to discuss what support you would

find useful?"

Activity 2 - Healthy or coercive?

Compare: (a) two partners agree on a savings plan and both can review transactions; (b) one partner

uses threats to demand all earnings. Suggested response: The first is potentially healthy cooperation;

the second indicates coercive financial control.

Activity 3 - Identify choices without giving orders

In Case C, list options for obtaining independent information without telling the person what to do.

Suggested response: Explain that a qualified adviser, legal-aid service, or trusted support person may

help review obligations. Safety and freedom to choose come first.

Activity 4 - Digital safety reflection

A person reports that someone else reads their mobile-money notifications. What should you avoid

suggesting automatically? Suggested response: Do not automatically recommend changing passwords

or disabling access, which might be noticed and increase risk; explore safer support with a specialist.

Activity 5 - Supportive communication practice

Rewrite "Why didn't you just leave?" into a respectful question. Suggested response: "What would feel

most helpful and safe for you right now?"

12. Knowledge assessment - questions and explained answers

1. Is economic abuse limited to stealing money?

Answer: No. It can also include employment sabotage, forced debt, property control, and denying

access to essential resources.

2. Does sharing a household bank account automatically mean abuse?

Answer: No. The key issue is whether control, threats, coercion, or exploitation remove meaningful

choice.

3. Can financial control occur in a family or caregiving relationship?

Answer: Yes. Economic abuse is not limited to intimate partners.

4. Why might a person remain financially dependent on someone harmful?

Answer: Safety, housing, food, childcare, debt, employment barriers, and other practical conditions may

limit options.

5. Is poverty an excuse for economic abuse?

Answer: No. Economic hardship may be a contextual factor, but responsibility belongs to the person

using coercion.

6. Can forced access to mobile-money PINs be concerning?

Answer: Yes, especially when demanded with threats, monitoring, or unauthorized use.

7. Should a supporter always tell someone to open a secret account?

Answer: No. Financial and digital actions should follow an individualized safety assessment.

8. Should you demand transaction screenshots to believe someone?

Answer: No. Listen respectfully and avoid unnecessary collection of sensitive personal data.

9. Can economic abuse continue after separation?

Answer: Yes. Debt, property, harassment, and account access may create continuing problems.

10. What is an appropriate first response?

Answer: Listen, validate, ask about immediate safety and needs, explain options and privacy limits, and

offer specialist referrals.

13. Facilitator notes and safeguarding

For group education, avoid asking participants to disclose personal experiences. Use fictional cases,

allow people to pass, do not collect names or financial information during exercises, and provide private

referral options. Do not promise that group discussions are confidential. Facilitators should know how to

respond if someone reports immediate danger or a child-safeguarding concern.

Rwanda-specific terminology, property and family-law statements, workplace rights, financial-service

procedures, and referral contacts must be checked by local GBV/legal professionals before publication.

Any digital version should minimize data collection and provide a safe exit option.

14. Accessing support in Rwanda

MIGEPROF describes Isange One Stop Centres as providing coordinated healthcare, psychosocial

support, legal and protection services. UNHCR Rwanda lists the Isange toll-free contact as 3029 and

notes that contacting a centre may result in a report to law enforcement. MIGEPROF also lists RIB 116 /

3512, Gender Monitoring Office 5798, and MIGEPROF 9059. Contact details and service arrangements

should be rechecked before public dissemination. [6, 7]

If a person is seeking assistance with property, contracts, debt, or employment disputes, a verified

Rwandan legal-aid provider or appropriate local institution should explain applicable rights. No outcome

can be guaranteed from this general educational material.

15. Key takeaways

- Economic abuse involves coercive control or exploitation of resources and opportunities.
- Financial abuse is one part of the broader concept of economic abuse.
- Warning signs include withheld necessities, confiscated earnings, forced debt, and work interference.
- Financial dependence is never a reason to blame a survivor.
- Support should protect autonomy, privacy, and safety, with specialist referral when appropriate.

16. Glossary

Economic abuse: Using resources or economic opportunities to control, exploit, or harm a person.

Financial abuse: Misuse or control of money, accounts, property, and financial decisions.

Employment sabotage: Interfering with a person's opportunity to obtain or maintain work.

Economic exploitation: Taking or using another person's financial resources or labor through coercion or

misuse of power.

Coercive control: A pattern of conduct that restricts another person's independence through

intimidation, threats, or other controlling tactics.

Survivor-centred support: Support that prioritizes the person's dignity, safety, informed choice, and

needs.

Digital financial safety: Considering risks from monitored devices, payment accounts, messages, and

transaction information.

17. Scientific and institutional references

[1] United Nations. What Is Domestic Abuse?

https://www.un.org/en/node/71778

[2] Women and Gender Equality Canada. Economic abuse.

https://www.canada.ca/en/women-gender-equality/gender-based-violence/economic-abuse.html

[3] National Network to End Domestic Violence. Financial Safety Planning; About Financial Abuse.

https://nnedv.org/content/financial-safety-planning/

[4] World Health Organization. Violence against women. 18 June 2026.

https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/violence-against-women

[5] World Health Organization. Health care for women subjected to intimate partner violence or sexual violence: a clinical handbook.

https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/WHO-RHR-14.26

[6] Ministry of Gender and Family Promotion (Rwanda). Directorate General of Family Promotion and Child Protection.

https://www.migeprof.gov.rw/family-promotion-and-child-right-protection

[7] UNHCR Rwanda. Gender-Based Violence - Services and Isange referrals.

https://help.unhcr.org/rwanda/services/sgbv/

[8] US National Institute of Justice. Economic Abuse in the Life of Survivors (2021).

https://nij.ojp.gov/library/publications/economic-abuse-life-survivors

18. Editorial and professional review checklist

- ☐ GBV specialist verified all descriptions of control and safety advice.
- ☐ Rwanda legal reviewer checked property, debt, employment, and reporting language.
- ☐ Local referral services and contacts are confirmed as current.
- ☐ Kinyarwanda and French translations are reviewed by qualified local experts.
- ☐ Accessible reading and mobile-format checks are completed.
- ☐ Public website content does not solicit sensitive financial or abuse disclosures unnecessarily.

END OF CHAPTER 08 | Education draft | Professional review required